With less than a year to go for the 2024 general election, the BJP has unfurled its grand gameplan to win a phenomenal third consecutive term at the Centre with a majority of its own, another iteration of the full spectrum dominance it achieved in 2014 and 2019. That mission took on an urgency of its own after 15 opposition parties gathered in Bihar's capital Patna on June 23 to see how they could combine their strengths to defeat the BJP.

To achieve its objective, the BJP has resorted to employing, among other things, shock and awe tactics. On June 27, at a meeting with booth workers in poll-bound Madhya Pradesh, Modi launched a calculated broadside at the Opposition for "guaranteeing corruption" in whichever state they ruled. He singled out the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), terming it a "scam meter that keeps ticking" and went on to say, "The NCP faces *ghotala* allegations of nearly Rs 70,000 crore, including the Maharashtra Cooperative Bank scam, Maharashtra irrigation scam and the illegal mining scam. The list is just too long." The next day, NCP chief Sharad Pawar brushed off the allegations, dismissing the speech as another example of the PM venting his frustrations at the Opposition's growing unity. But the joke would be on Pawar for five days later, on July 2, his nephew Ajit Pawar decided to split the NCP and join the BJP-Shiv Sena government in Maharashtra led by chief minister Eknath Shinde. Many observers read the PM's statement against the NCP as a barely veiled warning to Ajit Pawar and his band of supporters, the ones directly embroiled in the scams he had named, to stop dithering and join forces with the BJP or face the consequences.

## GAMEPLAN 2024

Maharashtra was not the only state in the BJP's rifle scope. A day after Ajit Pawar and nine NCP legislators were sworn in as cabinet ministers, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) filed a chargesheet against Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader Lalu Prasad Yadav and his son and Bihar deputy CM Tejashwi Yadav for their alleged involvement in a land-for-jobs scam from the mid-2000s when Lalu was the Union railways minister in the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government. The BJP has been smarting ever since Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar and his party, the Janata Dal (United) or JD(U), dumped their alliance government in August 2022. Nitish had switched sides and joined hands with the RJD to form a new coalition government in Bihar with Tejashwi as his deputy. Since then, the BJP has been plotting to destabilise the new formation. The latest move was meant to pile embarrassment and pressure on Nitish, narrowing

*Graphics by* TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

# THE TARGET STATES

**After its Maharashtra masterstroke, here's how the BJP is gearing up for 2024–from protecting its own turf in UP and Haryana to discrediting the ruling alliances in Tamil Nadu, Jharkhand and Bihar, from taking on a resurgent Congress in Karnataka and Himachal Pradesh to breaking new ground in Punjab, West Bengal and Odisha**

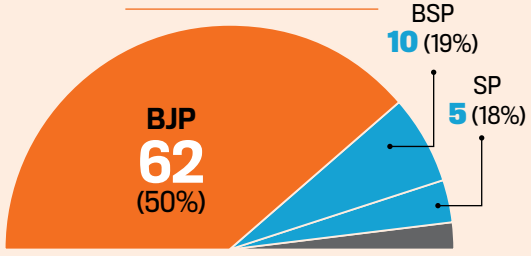
**SEATS WON IN 2019 BY**

BJP Key Opposition Others

Vote share in ( )

### UTTAR PRADESH

LS SEATS **80**




**THE CHALLENGE**

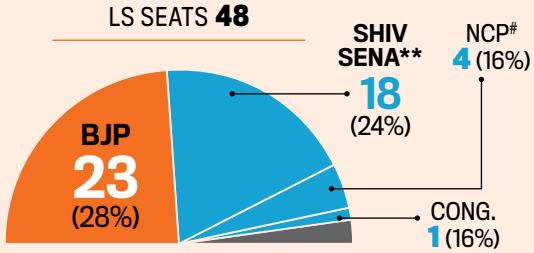
A rainbow alliance led by SP/ Congress could disturb BJP's electoral calculations

**BJP'S GAME PLAN**

Focus on seats lost in 2019; bank on BSP & RLD to disturb Opposition alliance plans; take credit for Ram temple and works done by 'double-engine *sarkar*'

### MAHARASHTRA

LS SEATS **48**




**THE CHALLENGE**

Despite split in Shiv Sena and NCP, their factions led by Uddhav Thackeray and Sharad Pawar, besides ally Congress, could gain sympathy vote

**BJP'S GAME PLAN**

Field prominent BJP state ministers; back strong leaders in Shiv Sena/ NCP breakaway factions; up the ante in Opposition strongholds